



English AI
Local Coach

ENGLISH AI · THEORY LESSON

Small Talk & Meeting New People

Vocabulary, useful phrases, grammar, writing and conversation practice

Level A2-B1 · 45-60 min · Lesson 07

LESSON GOAL

By the end of this lesson, you should be able to start a casual conversation, introduce yourself, ask natural follow-up questions, show interest, move between topics, and end a conversation politely.

Learn the conversation vocabulary first, then practise follow-up questions and short answers. Finish by using the Conversation Lab to meet an imaginary new person and keep the conversation going for several minutes.

Communication goal

Good small talk is not about saying something impressive. It is about making the other person comfortable, showing interest, and giving them something easy to respond to.

[START HERE](#)

Lesson map

A simple sequence: learn the key language, practise the structure, and then use it in a realistic conversation.

01

LEARN

Vocabulary + useful chunks

02

BUILD

Grammar + model dialogue

03

SPEAK

Writing + role-play

Warm-up

1. What topics do you usually talk about when you meet someone new?
2. Is it easy or difficult for you to start conversations in English?
3. What questions do you like people to ask you?
4. Which topics would you avoid with someone you have just met?

Before you continue

Answer the four questions in English using short sentences. Do not worry about mistakes yet. The goal is to activate the topic before studying the new language.



VOCABULARY 01

Essential vocabulary

Study the meaning and then read each example aloud. Try to connect each word to a real situation from your own life.

WORD / PHRASE	MEANING	EXAMPLE
small talk	conversa casual	We made small talk before the meeting.
introduce yourself	se apresentar	Let me introduce myself.
background	histórico / origem	Tell me a little about your background.
hometown	cidade natal	My hometown is in the countryside.
neighborhood	bairro	I live in a quiet neighborhood.
hobby	passatempo	One of my hobbies is playing tennis.
free time	tempo livre	What do you do in your free time?
interest	interesse	We have similar interests.
weekend	fim de semana	How was your weekend?
recommendation	recomendação	Do you have any restaurant recommendations?
conversation	conversa	We had a great conversation.
follow-up question	pergunta de continuação	Ask a follow-up question to show interest.
in common	em comum	We have a lot in common.
get to know	conhecer melhor	I would like to get to know the team.
catch up	colocar a conversa em dia	Let us catch up sometime.
nice to meet you	prazer em conhecer	It was nice to meet you.



VOCABULARY 02

Natural conversation building blocks

These short expressions help you react naturally instead of turning the conversation into a list of questions.

EXPRESSION	MEANING	EXAMPLE / USE
That sounds interesting.	Parece interessante.	Use it to react positively.
Really? How was it?	Sério? Como foi?	A simple follow-up after an experience.
What about you?	E você?	Return the question naturally.
How about you?	E você?	Another natural way to return a question.
No way!	Não acredito!	Informal surprise; use with friends or casual situations.
That makes sense.	Faz sentido.	Show that you understand.
I know what you mean.	Sei o que você quer dizer.	Show empathy or shared experience.
By the way,...	A propósito,...	Introduce a related or new topic.
Speaking of that,...	Falando nisso,...	Connect one topic to another.
Actually,...	Na verdade,...	Add or correct information.
It depends.	Depende.	Useful when there is no simple answer.
I am not really into...	Eu não curto muito...	A polite way to say you are not interested.

Study tip

Learn complete expressions, not only isolated words. In conversation, retrieving a ready-made chunk is much faster than building every sentence from zero.



USEFUL PHRASES

What to say in real situations

These phrases are designed to be spoken. Read them aloud and imagine the exact situation where you would use each one.

SITUATION	PHRASE	USE / MEANING
Starting	Hi, I do not think we have met. I am...	Natural introduction.
	How do you know everyone here?	Useful at social events.
	Is this your first time here?	Easy opening question.
Showing interest	What do you like most about it?	Ask for more detail.
	How did you get into that?	Ask how an interest started.
	What is that like?	Invite the person to explain.
Changing topic	By the way, have you tried...?	Move to a new topic.
	Speaking of travel, have you ever been to...?	Connect topics naturally.
	That reminds me...	Introduce a related thought.
Ending	It was great talking to you.	Friendly ending.
	I should get going, but it was nice meeting you.	Leave politely.
	Let us talk again soon.	Keep the connection open.

Make it yours

Choose three phrases from this page and rewrite them with details from your own life. Personal examples are easier to remember and use naturally.

GRAMMAR FOCUS

Present simple + natural follow-up questions

Use the present simple for routines, preferences, facts, and repeated activities. Then keep the conversation alive with a follow-up question related to what the other person just said.

PATTERN	EXAMPLE	USE
Present simple	I work in engineering.	fact / regular situation
Present simple	I usually play tennis on weekends.	routine
Do you...?	Do you play often?	ask about a habit
What / Where / How...?	Where do you usually play?	ask for detail
Follow-up	How did you get into tennis?	continue from their answer

Conversation formula

ANSWER + SMALL DETAIL + QUESTION. Example: "I live in Ribeirão Preto. I moved there a few years ago. What about you?"

Mini practice

Complete: I usually _____ with friends on weekends.

Turn into a question: You work from home. -> _____?

Write a follow-up question for: "I love cooking."

Add a question: "I am from Brazil. _____?"

MODEL DIALOGUE

Meeting someone at a social event

Notice how both people give short details and ask follow-up questions instead of only answering yes or no.

ALEX Hi, I do not think we have met. I am Alex.

MAYA Hi Alex, I am Maya. Nice to meet you.

ALEX Nice to meet you too. How do you know Daniel?

MAYA We studied together at university. What about you?

ALEX We work at the same company. I joined his team last year.

MAYA Oh, nice. What kind of work do you do?

ALEX I work with data and process improvement. It can be challenging, but I like it. What do you do?

MAYA I am a designer. I mostly work on digital products.

ALEX That sounds interesting. How did you get into design?

MAYA I started as a hobby in high school, and then I decided to study it professionally.

ALEX That is cool. By the way, have you tried the food here yet?

MAYA Not yet. Let us go check it out.

What makes it natural

Each person reacts to the previous answer, adds a small detail, and then asks something connected to the topic.

WRITING PRACTICE 01

Build useful sentences

Translate the sentences into English using the vocabulary and structures from this lesson. More than one answer may be correct.

1. Oi, acho que ainda não nos conhecemos.
2. O que você costuma fazer no seu tempo livre?
3. Como você começou a se interessar por isso?
4. Parece muito interessante.
5. Eu moro em uma cidade pequena. E você?
6. Nós temos muita coisa em comum.
7. Como foi o seu fim de semana?
8. Você vem aqui com frequência?
9. A propósito, você conhece algum restaurante bom por aqui?
10. Eu não curto muito futebol, mas gosto de tênis.
11. Foi muito bom conversar com você.
12. Preciso ir, mas foi um prazer conhecer você.

WRITING PRACTICE 02

Write a natural self-introduction

A good casual introduction is short, personal, and easy for the other person to respond to.

Task: Write 90-120 words introducing yourself to someone you have just met. Mention where you are from or where you live, what you do, two interests, something you usually do on weekends, and finish with a question for the other person.

Try to include some of these:

- I am from... / I live in...
- I am currently...
- In my free time, I...
- I am really into...
- On weekends, I usually...
- What about you?
- How about you?

Simple structure

WHO YOU ARE -> 2 OR 3 DETAILS -> RETURN THE CONVERSATION. Give enough information for the other person to choose a topic and continue.

Self-check before you finish

- ☐ Did I give more than one-word answers?
- ☐ Did I include information that invites a response?
- ☐ Did I ask at least one natural question?
- ☐ Could I say it without sounding memorized?

CONVERSATION PRACTICE

Role-plays for the AI coach

Open the Conversation Lab and complete each situation before asking the AI to correct you. Try to stay in English even when you need time to think.

Role-play 1 · New classmate

The AI is a new classmate. Introduce yourself, talk about where you are from, what you study or do, hobbies, and weekend plans.

Role-play 2 · Friend of a friend

You meet the AI at a birthday party. Find at least three things you have in common and keep the conversation going for five minutes.

Role-play 3 · Networking coffee

The AI is someone from another company. Start casually, discuss work and interests, then end the conversation politely and suggest staying in touch.

Questions to practise

- Where are you from?
- What do you do?
- What do you like to do in your free time?
- How did you get into that?
- What have you been doing lately?
- How was your weekend?
- Do you have any plans for this week?
- What about you?

REVIEW

Mini test

Complete this without looking back. The goal is to see what you can produce from memory, not only what you recognize on the page.

1. Translate: cidade natal = _____
2. Translate: tempo livre = _____
3. Translate: colocar a conversa em dia = _____
4. Complete: What do you do _____ your free time?
5. Complete: How did you get _____ that?
6. Write one reaction to show interest.
7. Translate: “Nós temos muita coisa em comum.”
8. Translate: “A propósito, você já esteve aqui antes?”
9. Write a follow-up question for: “I work with software.”
10. Write a follow-up question for: “I went hiking last weekend.”
11. What is the three-part conversation formula?
12. Start a conversation with someone you have not met before.
13. Change the topic using “By the way”.
14. End a conversation politely.
15. Write a two-sentence answer to “What do you do in your free time?”

ANSWER KEY

Check and learn from your mistakes

Some answers can vary. The versions below are natural examples using the language taught in this lesson.

Grammar mini practice

- play / spend / meet (answers vary)
- Do you work from home?
- Example: What do you like to cook?
- Example: Where are you from?

Writing practice 01 - Suggested answers

1. Hi, I do not think we have met yet.
2. What do you usually do in your free time?
3. How did you get into that?
4. That sounds very interesting.
5. I live in a small town. What about you?
6. We have a lot in common.
7. How was your weekend?
8. Do you come here often?
9. By the way, do you know any good restaurants around here?
10. I am not really into soccer, but I like tennis.
11. It was great talking to you.
12. I should get going, but it was nice meeting you.

Review strategy

Mark the sentences that felt slow or uncertain. Say those sentences aloud three times, then create one new example with the same structure.

FINISH

Mini test answers + progress check

Use the score only as a guide. The real objective is to understand the topic and communicate without stopping every time you need a new sentence.

1. hometown
2. free time
3. catch up
4. in
5. into
6. Example: That sounds interesting.
7. We have a lot in common.
8. By the way, have you been here before?
- 9-10. Answers vary; ask for a related detail.
11. Answer + small detail + question.
- 12-15. Answers vary; use the lesson patterns.

READY FOR CONVERSATION?

If you can do these four things, move to the Conversation Lab.

- ✓ Start a conversation naturally.
- ✓ Give short answers with useful details.
- ✓ Ask follow-up questions based on what you hear.
- ✓ Change topic and end a conversation politely.

Next lesson suggestion: Public Transportation & Getting Around